marriage-age women doesn't give those lucky enough to get a college education an advantage in picking a desirable mate, perhaps someone who will let them pursue a career. But then I'm reminded of how Sita's future is already picked out for her.

Sita's disappointment comes not from the thought of being married but from having no say in the marriage or what comes after. When I press her on this, she talks a bit about her mother, who has followed her father around India and now lives in an area where she doesn't speak the language. Westerners may think that Hindi is the national language, but it is spoken primarily in the north. Tamil is the language of hundreds of millions in the south, and Sita's mother can't understand it. Then with whom does her mother talk? Only her family and old friends back home, on the telephone, replies Sita. I see a shadow of fear on her face, maybe as she imagines being as isolated as her mother.

It will be particularly hard for Sita to move back north. Although she speaks Hindi as a native tongue, and therefore won't be as cut off from society around her as her mother, social conditions in the north may make life difficult. It is poorer than the south and its cities are comparatively worse. Driving around Calcutta a week later, I see thousands of Biharis who fled their state into Calcutta's West Bengal, and are now living in filthy, crumbling lean-tos and shanties on the city's streets. For someone like Sita, who has dreamed of living in Bangalore, the north offers little enticement.

The north of India is also more socioeconomically volatile than other areas of the country. During 2010, farmers rampaged against police near Delhi over land repossession, killing several officers, and Maoist guerillas from a decades-old insurgency ambushed eleven policemen in the northeast.[12] It is also relatively less educated. Tamil Nadu, the southern state in which Chennai is located, has hundreds of colleges and universities, from the flagship University of Madras to tiny private schools that can be hardly better than vocational centers. Regardless, the opportunities for education beyond secondary school are nonetheless readily available in the southern Deccan region. And as a glance at any of the moderately established higher education